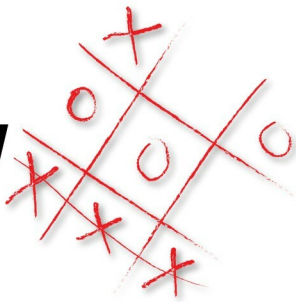


Still Radically Simple



...but is that enough? PCLinuxOS 2009.1 has finally been released after a wait of almost two years. We take a look at how the new version of this former Distrowatch topper fares.

It's only fair to first mention a few words about myself. I have been a hardcore Windows user, until about two years back. Since then, although I have been running Mandriva on my machine, I was still predominantly a Windows user because I am a professional gamer. As typical with most OS migrators (especially from Windows), KDE was my very first choice to test drive, and I have stayed glued to it till date. Hence, it's no wonder that I was asked to review PCLinuxOS 2009 the moment our IT admin downloaded it (owing to its similarity with Mandriva, and KDE runs on it, by default).

Background check

PCLinuxOS is a GNU/Linux distribution that was built on Mandriva and was launched as a set of RPM packages. Bill Reynolds (a.k.a. Textstar) had created PCLOS as a fulfillment of his wish to package source code without having to deal with the rest of the world. It later evolved into a complete desktop operating system with its own unique set of features. The distro's stability and ease of use made it popular pretty fast and even topped the distro ranking at Distrowatch in 2007.

Configuration of the test machine

I ran it on a pretty low-end laptop, a Compaq Presario C300, with the following specs:

- Motherboard: Intel 915
- Processor: Celeron M 1.67 MHz
- Memory: 512 MB DDR
- Hard Disk: 60 GB SATA

The installation

After I booted the machine off the LiveCD, I was presented with the option of a LiveCD install and a few safe modes. There was no option to install PCLOS 2009.1 right away. Anyway, before loading the operating system, I was asked for my keyboard layout and was directly presented with the log-in screen.

The default IDs are as usual, 'guest' and 'root', with their respective passwords mentioned at the top left of the screen. I logged in as the root user right away because I wanted to install this baby on my machine, ASAP.

While you log in, you are presented with a loading screen that actually shows various icons symbolising each of PCLOS' major releases. Although I am not too confident if it is a welcome change from KDE's traditional loading screen, I am sure I would